



SESSION 4: MENTOR GUIDE

My inner voice

This is a vulnerable session. Many athletes are ashamed of negative self-talk. Actively normalize it.

SESSION GOAL

Help the athlete become aware of their self-talk patterns and develop a more constructive inner voice.

CONVERSATION FLOW

OPENING (5 MIN)

""How do you talk to yourself when you make a mistake? Can you tell me honestly?""

💡 Go first yourself: "I know I used to be very hard on myself too..." That opens the door.

EXPLORING (15 MIN)

""Has that inner voice always been there, or did someone teach it to you at some point?""

💡 Self-talk has an origin. Discovering it can be liberating.

DEEPENING (10 MIN)

""What would change in your performance if that voice became kinder?""

💡 Research shows: self-compassion increases performance. Share this if it fits.

CLOSING (5 MIN)

""Let's formulate an anchor sentence together. Let the athlete choose it.""

💡 The sentence must be theirs, not your suggestion. Ask: "Which sentence sounds like yours?"

OBSERVE

- How quickly does the athlete acknowledge negative self-talk? Or do they deny it?
- Is there a pattern? (After mistakes? Under pressure? With certain players?)
- What is the emotion when they describe that inner voice? Shame, humor, pain?
- Note: extreme self-criticism can be a signal of something deeper. Flag it.

△ NOTE

If self-criticism is extreme ("I'm useless", "I don't deserve my spot"), normalize it, but flag this internally as a point of attention. Refer if needed.

CLOSING

Repeat their anchor sentence back: "The sentence you choose is..." Make it concrete: "When are you going to use that this week?" That increases the chance of transfer.

MENTOR NOTES